

SAURABH SINGH



# The Lost Horizon

Chakravarti's novel is a requiem for a vanishing Goa, the land of the baker on his creaking bicycle and the perfect vin d'alho

ONCE UPON A TIME IN APARANTA

by SUDEEP CHAKRAVARTI

Penguin

Price: Rs 250

Pages: 220

■ By Bunny Suraiya

Back in the days when he lived in Delhi, I used to meet Sudeep Chakravarti fairly often. The talk would often turn—as it still does—to getting away from it all, opting out of the rat race and all the other urban clichés that get trotted out as the hour grows late. Unlike all the rest of us midnight philosophers, however, Chakravarti had the courage to follow his dream. *Once Upon a Time in Aparanta* is the result.

Aparanta, the Land at the Horizon, is Goa, and Chakravarti's book—a tale of two cousins—is a requiem for a paradise lost and an impassioned plea for it to be regained. For Goa, “where there is always time” and, “after a few drinks, timelessness”, is losing its soul, betrayed not only by the outsiders who flock to it but also by its own children driven by greed and riven by ambition.

The author's love for his adopted home is evident in many lovely descriptive passages, such as the one about the daily visit of the *poder* (baker), which is

among my own treasured Goan memories: “The poder had just been by on his creaking, rusted cycle...with the insistent pom-pom-pom of the tiny bulb of a wind horn tied with bits of electric wire to the handlebar (bringing the) flat, poyee wheat bread and...undea, the hard roll with a soft heart...”. Equally heart-warming is an almost-recipe for the true Goan vin d'alho (“never vindaloo”)—“a little sour with sweet wine, so much red chilli to make our friend Lucifer sweat, and soothed with the finest pork”. Indeed, Chakravarti has got it bang on; few people outside of Goa—and perhaps Portugal—know that “vin” in the name of the dish refers to wine and is not a diminutive for vinegar.

This Goa, of the *poder*, the vin d'alho, the home-brewed cashew feni, the Sunday church service; the Goa of family values and camaraderie, is in danger of being lost forever in the new era of corrupt politicians, Russian Mafiosi, Israeli gangsters, narcotics traders and rapacious Indian carpet-baggers putting up monstrous constructions everywhere and despoiling the land. Chakravarti's angst is mirrored by the reader's own despairing sense of a hideous reality being imposed on one of the last idylls left in India. It could act as a wake-up call for the powers that be. Is anyone listening? ■

# Insect Bites

This collection of short fiction is a fine example of retro-comic chic



INSECTS ARE JUST LIKE YOU AND ME EXCEPT SOME OF THEM HAVE WINGS

by KUZHALI MANICKAVEL

Blaft Publications

Price: Rs 195; Pages: 144

■ By Geeta Doctor

If you were around in the mid-20th century, you will recall comic strips that ended with the words: Har! Har! Har! It was meant to indicate something which was so obviously inane that it could pass for being profound. Har! Har! Har! This is the tone that distinguishes a slim volume of short fiction by Kuzhali Manickavel, who is being hailed as “one of India's most original young writers”. The publishers also seek to present themselves as young and cutting edge for a place like Chennai. It's an elegantly produced volume with illustrations that tie in with the insect motif by Malavika P.C. The whole enterprise could be called retro-comic chic. An instant rewind to the days when a certain enervated energy, not unlike that of a bee trapped in a bell jar, passed for radical action. Life is defined by the most inconsequential details that glow and twitch as in Tom Wolfe's *The Electric Kool-aid Acid Kit Test*—the Bible of hysteria as a form of observation.

Whether it's meant to be a homage to them or not, Manickavel makes references to some of the icons of that era—from Che Guevara to Sylvia Plath and T.S. Eliot. It underlines the sense of dislocation that characterises her gaze. Despite adopting a knowingness about the Tamil milieu that she holds up for us to understand, it's always from the outside—the clever entomologist catching flies for fun and profit.

To be fair, Manickavel has a sharp eye for detail. Her stories are short and vivid, in the manner of a conversation overheard on a bus or train. She could be a good maker of docudramas that encapsulate a person's situation in five minutes. And in case you need to know how to say the f-word in Tamil, this is the book for you. Har! Har! Har! ■